



semifinal where he outlasted No. 20 Frances Tiafoe, a muscle-flexing showman, 4-6, 7-5, 4-6, 6-4, 6-1 to become the first American man since Andy Roddick in 2006 to reach the US Open final. Roddick was also the last American man to win a Grand Slam singles title, way back in 2003 at Flushing Meadows.

The good-looking, soft-spoken California Kid sounded confident he could end the 21-year drought. "I have a feeling I'm going to come out and play really well and win," Fritz said. "When I play good tennis, I think that level is good enough to win."

It certainly wasn't anywhere near "good enough," as Sinner outplayed Fritz 6-3, 6-4, 7-5 to become only the fourth man in 50 years to win his first two Majors in the same calendar year. (Jimmy Connors won three Majors in 1974!)

Patrick McEnroe sounded cautiously optimistic about current American standouts Fritz, Tiafoe, and Tommy Paul. "You're close, but you're still pretty far [from winning a Major]. They still have to improve a lot of

little things in their games."

McEnroe was more certain about Sinner and Alcaraz. "Are these two guys going to dominate the way the Big Three did? Yes."

Sinner went on to win 18 of his last 19 matches, losing only to Alcaraz 6-7 (6), 6-4, 7-6 (3) in a sensational Beijing final. "Alcaraz has a gear that goes to 11 [out of 10], even against Sinner," said former No. 1 Jim Courier.

In the season-ending ATP Finals, Sinner put an exclamation point on his tremendous year there, decisively defeating De Minaur, Medvedev, Ruud, and Fritz (twice).

SABALENKA DETHRONES SWIATEK IN NEW TENNIS WORLD ORDER

Ever since Serena Williams won her 23rd and final Grand Slam singles title eight years ago, no dominant women's superstar has emerged in a sport that thrives on great players and riveting rivalries.

Iga Swiatek came closest with five Majors, but her reign was mainly on clay, as her four French Open victories attested. The intense Pole,

Queen of clay: By her high standards, Iga Swiatek's season was disappointing, yet she still claimed her fourth French Open and fifth Grand Slam title, winning titles in Madrid and Rome, and securing a bronze medal at the Paris Olympics, all on her favoured surface. GETTY IMAGES

limited by a one-dimensional game, has reached the semifinals just twice in the past eight Majors. Before her, Naomi Osaka appeared to be Serena's heir apparent with a similar high-powered game. Alas, the Japanese player's success was limited to four Major titles on hard courts. Following a hiatus during which she gave birth to a daughter in July 2023, she has yet to regain her championship form. Australian Ash Barty, the best pure athlete since Justine Henin, captured a Major on each surface, only to retire abruptly after winning her home Slam three years ago.

In 2024, Aryna Sabalenka increasingly looked like the superstar